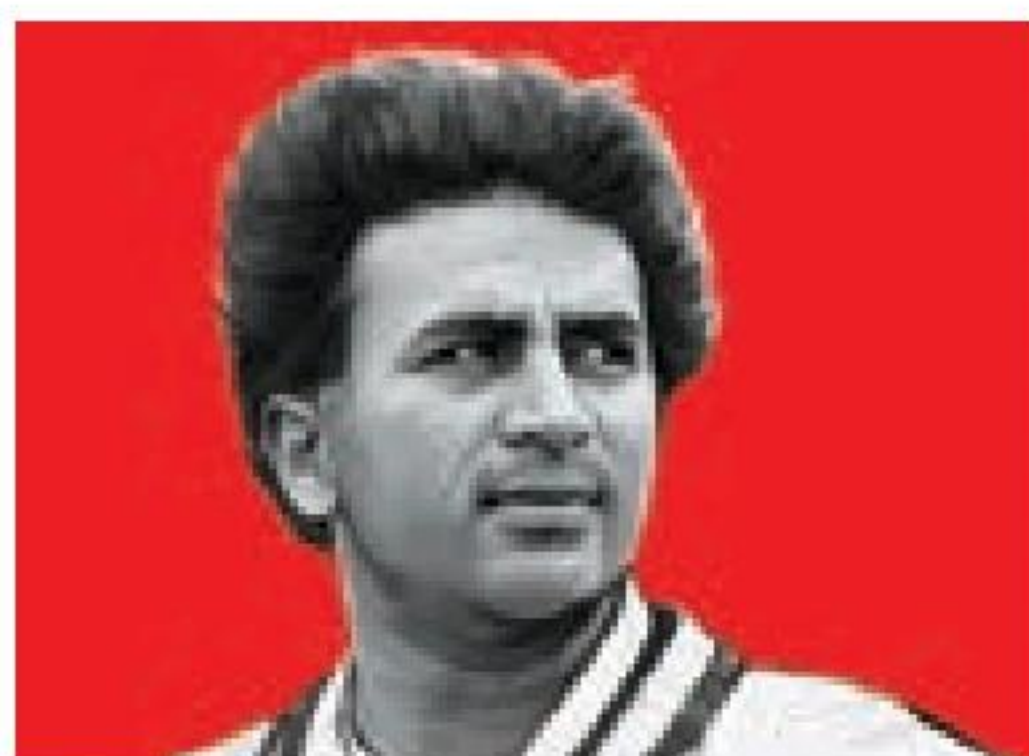




ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



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INDIA'S SERIES LOSS TO IRELAND ONE OF THE LOWEST POINTS IN ITS CRICKET HISTORY

If Ireland had played exceptional cricket, then it would have lessened the blow. It was simply **overconfidence** and a sense of casualness that let India down, and that's why the sadness.

Sunday, June 28, will go down as one of the worst days in Indian cricket. Losing a game of cricket is one thing, but to lose a series, albeit a two-match series, also depends on whom you lose to. There are many low points in Indian cricket, and I have been a part of some, but to lose to Ireland has to be one of the lowest in the history of Indian cricket. If Ireland had played exceptional cricket, then it would have lessened the blow. It was simply overconfidence and a sense of casualness that let India down, and that's why the sadness.

It was very much like West Indies in the final of the 1983 World Cup. India's bowlers bowled smart, tight lines and lengths, and there was that outstanding, game-turning catch by the skipper, Kapil Dev, to get rid of Viv Richards, who looked intent on finishing the game in a canter. When you look at West Indies batters' dismissals, you will see the same overconfidence and casualness that we saw

from the Indian batters in both games against Ireland.

Playing according to the situation is such an important aspect of any sport, especially cricket, but almost all the Indian batters tried to live up to their image and, on pitches that had a little extra carry and bounce, found that they were dismissed very easily by some good catching allied to smart bowling.

While the eventual result may justify not picking Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, this series was the ideal opportunity to give the young man a taste of international cricket. Hopefully, they will not waste any more time and will play him in the very first game against England in a few days' time. Of course, the young man could fail, but if he gets going, then he will take the game away from the host and give India the chance to start the series with a bang.

The Indian women losing to Australia wasn't a big surprise, but it didn't make the day any better. They should have beaten South Africa, but so abysmal was their fielding against them